palace’ wrote a surprised Jesuit, ‘and there are so many saints that…you would say it was more like the palace of a Christian King than a Moorish one’. Akbar would show the engravings and European paintings to his favourite Hindu painters and they would learn European concepts of volume, perspective, and space in addition to the painting of angels, and of the holy figures, and use them in ingenious ways. It was probably just as well that the Jesuit priests did not live to see the use that Akbar made of their beloved sacred images as, according to Kavita Singh, ‘Mughal imperial painting would eventually appropriate the tropes of Catholic devotional art to aggrandize the image of Mughal Emperors’. The lustrous halos, the taut-skinned cherubs, and the allegorical imagery would be incorporated into Mughal miniatures, using all available symbology to glorify the Padshahs of Hindustan.

Paradoxically Badauni, the acerbic critic, was the one who would most lucidly analyse Akbar’s theological and philosophical bent. ‘From childhood to manhood and from manhood to his declining years the Emperor had combined in himself various phases from various religions and opposite sectarian beliefs and by a peculiar acquisitiveness and a talent for selection by no means common, had made his own all that can be seen and read in books.’ As a result, continued Badauni, Akbar believed that ‘there are wise men to be found and ready at hand in all religions, and men of asceticism and recipients of revelation and workers of miracles among all nations and that the Truth is an inhabitant of everyplace’.

While Akbar was discussing the finer points of Christian theology with the Jesuits in the ibadat khana, he was also busy subduing what had become one of the most serious challenges to his rule. After the audacious mazhar and the reading of the khutba, there was a gathering momentum of those who believed that Islam itself was under threat because of Akbar. Far away in Bengal a disaffected mullah, Qazi Muhammad Yazdi, had denounced Akbar as an infidel and had issued a fatwa of kufr (disbelief), calling on all righteous Muslims to take up arms and to revolt against the Padshah. The contender for the throne, under whose name they would unite was that long-forgotten brother, relegated and confined these many years to Babur’s old capital at Kabul, Mirza Hakim.